

THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE

Executive Development Memo #001 — Launch Year & Franchise Name
An alternate-reality “what if” • Fidelity Rating: 100% • Nerf Tolerance: 0%

1. The Decision

FRANCHISE: The Motown Universe (TMU)

FIRST FILM: *Hitsville* — 2009

World premiere Mon. Jan 12, 2009 (Fox Theatre, Detroit) • Wide release Fri. May 1, 2009

2. Why 2009 Is the Perfect Year

- **The Golden Anniversary.** Berry Gordy founded Tamla Records on **January 12, 1959** with an **\$800 loan** from his family's savings fund. January 12, 2009 is the 50th anniversary to the day — the premiere date writes its own press release.
- **The blueprint is fresh.** *Iron Man* (May 2, 2008) proved the shared-universe model. Launching one year later lets TMU follow the playbook while it is new, and taking the first-Friday-in-May slot mirrors Marvel's own launch window.
- **Audiences want music biopics.** *Ray* (2004) and *Walk the Line* (2005) were critical and commercial hits. *Dreamgirls* (2006) fictionalized a Supremes-style story. TMU answers that with the **real names, real songs and real chart history**.
- **Detroit's comeback story.** In 2009 GM and Chrysler went through bankruptcy. Gordy took the assembly-line idea from his time at the Lincoln-Mercury plant and used it to build a hit factory. A movie about Detroit building something world-class out of nothing lands hardest that year.
- **The legends can advise us.** In 2009 Berry Gordy, Smokey Robinson, Stevie Wonder, Diana Ross, Mary Wilson, Martha Reeves and Holland–Dozier–Holland were all alive to consult. We never get a better chance to check the facts with the people who were there.

Sensitivity note

Michael Jackson died on June 25, 2009, during our first year. The Jackson 5 story stays in a later phase and gets full-strength, respectful treatment. It is never rushed out to cash in.

3. Why “The Motown Universe” Is the Perfect Name

Candidate	Verdict
The Motown Universe (TMU)	SELECTED. Leads with the brand. Its acronym, TMU, is ours alone. It matches the project name we already use.
Motown Cinematic Universe	Rejected. The “MCU” acronym belongs to Marvel. We'd be a copy on day one.
Hitsville Cinematic Universe	Rejected as the franchise name because “Hitsville” is better used as the title of Film #1.
The Sound of Young America Universe	Too long as a name. Kept as the official tagline , since it was Motown's real slogan.

Lockup: *THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE* — *The Sound of Young America*. Studio-logo idea: the Hitsville U.S.A. house at **2648 West Grand Boulevard**, Detroit, lighting up as a Funk Brothers groove plays.

4. Phase One Preview — “The Hitsville Era” (2009–2012)

This is a draft slate built on the MCU structure: solo origin films leading to a team-up. Every milestone listed is part of the documented record.

Year	Film	Historical anchor	MCU parallel
2009	Hitsville	Gordy founds Tamla (1959). Barrett Strong's “Money (That's What I Want)”. The film ends on “Shop Around” (1960), the label's first million-seller. <i>Post-credits scene</i> : Ronnie White of the Miracles brings an 11-year-old Stevland Morris to audition (1961).	Iron Man
2010	Shop Around	Smokey Robinson & the Miracles. Smokey is Gordy's first act, his top songwriter and a future Motown vice president.	Captain America
2010	Please Mr. Postman	The Marvelettes, a group of Inkster High School students, score Motown's first Hot 100 #1 (Dec. 1961).	Guardians-style breakout
2011	My Guy	Mary Wells becomes Motown's first superstar. Smokey writes and produces the song, which hits #1 in 1964.	Black Widow
2011	Fingertips	“Little Stevie Wonder” hits #1 in 1963 at age 13 with a live recording.	Spider-Man
2012	The Motortown Revue	The ensemble tour of late 1962, with the Funk Brothers backing everyone. It covers the Jim Crow South, including tour members' accounts of the bus being shot at in Birmingham. It ends with the “no-hit Supremes” on the bus, setting up Phase Two.	The Avengers

5. Studio Mandates (Non-Negotiable)

The Fidelity Mandate

- The “source material” is the **master recordings, Billboard chart history, and first-hand memoirs**: Gordy's *To Be Loved* (1994), Smokey's *Smokey: Inside My Life* (1989), Mary Wilson's *Dreamgirl: My Life as a Supreme* (1986), Martha Reeves' *Dancing in the Street* (1994), and Allan Slutsky's *Standing in the Shadows of Motown* (1989).
- Names, dates, chart positions and songwriting credits must match the record. We do not invent composite characters to stand in for real people.
- Gordy is shown whole: a genius and a hard-driving boss. That includes the Friday Quality Control meetings, the move to LA in 1972, and the \$61M sale to MCA/Boston Ventures in 1988.

The No-Nerf Mandate

- **Nobody gets nerfed.** Every artist appears at their full documented level of talent and achievement. Examples: the Supremes' 12 Hot 100 #1s, Stevie playing many instruments, Marvin Gaye's three-octave-plus range, and Smokey as a poet-level lyricist.
- The **Funk Brothers** get full on-screen credit and real story arcs, especially James Jamerson (bass) and Benny Benjamin (drums). They are not background extras.
- **Holland–Dozier–Holland**, Norman Whitfield, Mickey Stevenson and the whole writing and production staff get the same treatment as the stars.
- Every performance uses the original masters or a live vocal that matches the record. Weak lip-syncs are not allowed.

TMU is a fan-made alternate-reality concept. It has no connection to Motown Records, Universal Music Group or Marvel Studios.